



Sex, Gender, Jews

Jewish Studies, Religion Studies, Women, Gender, & Sexuality Studies 138 Spring 2026

Professor Jodi Eichler-Levine

Contact Information

E-mail: joe315@lehigh.edu

Office Hours: By appointment; see link on Course Site.

Course Meets: Maginess 103 T/R 9:20-10:35

*Please note—email is the best way to reach me, but I receive an enormous number of messages. In your e-mails, please always indicate in which course you are enrolled and allow **up to 48 hours** for a response (longer on weekends).

About This Course

How do Jews of all genders tell their stories? What are the varied Jewish approaches to sexuality? How have feminist movements affected Jewish rituals? In this course, we will consider how religion, gender, sexuality, race, and class intersect in the lives of Jews, with a particular focus on women in North America. Topics will include: Jewish women's writing; the voices of LGBTQ Jews; recent innovations in Jewish ritual and leadership; Jewish masculinities; and the gendering of Jewish children's literature, among others.



Lofty Notions

Why religion, culture, and society?

Understanding different religious traditions--in this case, mostly Judaism--and their internal diversity helps you to encounter other people thoughtfully, to understand world history, and to be a strong citizen.



Why women, gender and sexuality studies?

We all have bodies. We all experience gender and sexuality in various ways. Focusing on the myriad ways gender is practiced and constructed among one particular group raises broader questions in this field as a whole.

Learning Objectives

1) Oral and written communication

We will improve these through writing, engaged reading practices, class discussions, and presentations. Revision will be an important part of our writing practices.

2) Understanding intercultural differences

We will be closely examining the intersectional nature of many aspects of identity, including religion, gender, sexuality, race, ethnicity, class, and more.

3) Examining underlying concepts

We often take major ideas about how the world works for granted--for example, what religion is or how gender functions-- without taking into account their full history and context. This course will ask you to do this hard work.



1) CHECK YOUR EMAIL REGULARLY AND LISTEN IN CLASS.

I communicate with the class primarily through 1) emails, and 2) announcements in class. Pay attention to both. Get contact information for a few other students on the first day so you can learn about any announcements/notes if you miss all or part of class. **Always include your name and what course you are taking in your email.**

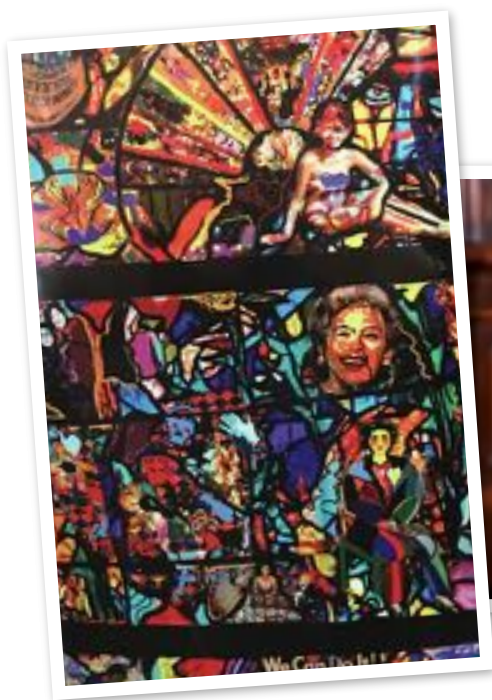
2) **Writing and humans:** As a **humanist** and also a social scientist (a bit of both), I study things that **humans** do and create. ChatGPT and other forms of Generative AI don't yet pass the Turing test (which is itself a [bit problematic](#)). Even if they could, that's still pretty far from "human." Even if ChatGPT or Gemini were sentient, **they would not be you.** What I care about in my class is **getting to know YOU through written and spoken language.** Sure, you can produce your writing through a bot, but 1) It will be boring writing, and 2) I won't actually be in conversation with YOU, which is supposed to be the whole point of college.

There ARE good use cases for generative AI, and we will probably have some assignments, particularly short, in-class assignments, where we do experiment with these tools. But they will not be our first recourse in this writing intensive class. We will be having many writing experiences! You will work with me and with our TRAC fellows on writing and revising throughout the semester.

3) **Here is the Lehigh University Undergraduate Student Senate Statement on Academic Integrity:** We, the Lehigh University Student Senate, as the standing representative body of all undergraduates, reaffirm the duty and obligation of students to meet and uphold the highest principles and values of personal, moral and ethical conduct. As partners in our educational community, both students and faculty share the responsibility for promoting and helping to ensure an environment of academic integrity. As such, each student is expected to complete all academic course work in accordance to the standards set forth by the faculty and in compliance with the University's Code of Conduct.

4) **Lehigh University Policy on Harassment and NonDiscrimination.** Lehigh University upholds the Principles of our Equitable Community and is committed to an educational, working, co-curricular, social, and living environment for faculty, staff, and students. The University does not discriminate in its admissions practices, employment practices, or educational programs or activities on the basis of age, color, disability, ethnicity, familial status, gender expression, gender identity, genetic information, marital status, national origin (including shared ancestry), pregnancy or related conditions, race, religion, sex, sexual orientation, and veteran or military status. Harassment or discrimination is unacceptable behavior and will not be tolerated. The University strongly encourages (and, depending upon the circumstances, may require) students, faculty, or staff who experience or witness harassment or discrimination, or have information about harassment or discrimination in University programs or activities, to immediately report such conduct. If you have questions about [Lehigh's Policy on Harassment and Non-Discrimination](#) or need to report harassment or discrimination, contact the Equal Opportunity Compliance Coordinator (Alumni Memorial Building 610 758 3535 eocc@lehigh.edu)

5) **Accommodations for Students with Disabilities.** Lehigh University is committed to maintaining an equitable and inclusive community and welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University's educational programs. In order to receive consideration for reasonable accommodations, a student with a disability must contact Disability Support Services (DSS), provide documentation, and participate in an interactive review process. If the documentation supports a request for reasonable accommodations, DSS will provide students with a Letter of Accommodations. Students who are approved for accommodations at Lehigh should share this letter and discuss their accommodations and learning needs with instructors as early in the semester as possible. For more information or to request services, please contact Disability Support Services in person in Williams Hall, Suite 301, via phone at 610-758-4152, via email at indss@lehigh.edu, or online at <https://studentaffairs.lehigh.edu/disabilities>.



Assignments

Further details on all assignments will be posted on Course Site.

CLASS ATTENDANCE AND PARTICIPATION

Learning happens in conversation. I do lecture sometimes. But I am just not the kind of professor who stands there and talks for over an hour. There will be in class activities; materials that we read in class together and then discuss; group work; in-class writing; and hands-on activities. There might even be arts and crafts. Although I will circulate an attendance sheet to sign, this part of your grade is much more about participation than the exact number of classes attended. Obviously, if you miss two weeks in a row, without a documented reason like a medical emergency, that's bad. But what I want to see the most from you is **engagement and conversation**. That said, please do not come to class if you are ill. Keep your germs at home! If you miss a class, **you** are responsible for contacting a classmate for notes and any announcements. I will not "catch you up."

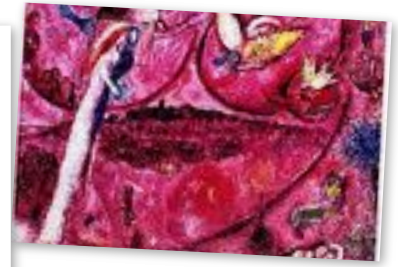


VALUE: 20 percent of final grade— combination of speaking and writing activities

MICRO INTELLECTUAL MEMOIR

This is how I will get to know you— and what questions you are bringing to this course. In approximately 3 typed, double-spaced pages tell me how *you* have thought about this class's topics before (that includes informal learning—no prior related classes are expected, but certainly mention them if you have taken them); what makes you curious when you look at this syllabus— and what worries you about the material or what you might find challenging this term. Details on Coursesite.

VALUE: 10 percent of final grade DUE DATE: Monday, January 26, 12 NOON



PAPERS

Paper 1: 5 pages (typed, double-spaced, prompt TBD) Rough draft due date: February 17

Final draft due date: March 3, end of day (11:59 pm)

Paper 2: 5 pages (prompt TBD) Rough draft due date: March 24 Final draft: April 14 (11:59 pm)

Value: 40 percent of final grade (20 percent each)

FINAL PROJECT: EXPLORE THE ENCYCLOPEDIA OF JEWISH WOMEN PROJECT

For this assignment, you will do research branching off from one entry in the [Shalvi/Hyman Encyclopedia of Jewish Women](#) (it has to be an entry that was *not* assigned for class). You will work on a project that involves some outside research with some reflection on what you have learned in class (connecting the entry very specifically to some of our class readings, viewings, and in-class materials). You will use that research to write your own original paper. The *format* of how you submit this will be primarily written, but it might incorporate images or other multimedia. Many more details to come. We will devote class workshop time to this project.



Due date: Various, scaffolded throughout the semester. FINAL due April 30, 11:59 pm

Value: 30 percent of final grade for ALL parts (topic selection, bibliography, drafts, final project)

I reserve the right to alter this syllabus as needed!

READING SCHEDULE

Readings should be completed *before* the course date for which they are assigned. The instructor may add or remove readings on Course Site.

TJAN 20: Welcome!

Welcome! Introductions and in-class activities.



RJAN 22: Telling Jewish Experiences

Margie Piercy (she/her), *The Art of Blessing the Day*, excerpts

Loolwa Khazzoom (she/her), “United Jewish Feminist Front,” from *Yentl’s Revenge* (Seal Press, 2001), 161-181

TJAN 27: Jews and Gender I

Pamela Nadell, (she/her) “A Bright New Constellation: Feminism and American Judaism.” In Marc Raphael, ed., *The Columbia History of Jews and Judaism in America* (New York, Columbia University Press, 2008), 385-405

Judith Plaskow (she/her), *The Coming of Lilith: Essays on Feminism, Judaism, and Sexual Ethics*, 1972-2003 (Boston: Beacon Press, 2005), excerpts

SEE ALSO: Timeline posted for this day

R JAN 29: Jews and Gender II

Beth S. Wenger (she/her), “Constructing Manhood in American Jewish Culture”

Elliot Rose Kukla (he/him), “‘Created by the Hand of Heaven: Sex, Love, and the Androgynos”



Reading schedule: continued

TFEB 3: Rabbis (And Rabbas)

Angela Warnick Buchdahl, (she/her) *Heart of a Stranger*, excerpt

Blu Greenberg (she/her), "Sara Hurwitz." *Shalvi/Hyman Encyclopedia of Jewish Women*. 30 December 2021. Jewish Women's Archive. <https://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/hurwitz-sara>



RFEB 5: Musical Leadership

Jewish Women's Archive. "Debbie Friedman." <https://jwa.org/feminism/friedman-debbie>

Deborah E. Lipstadt (she/her), "'And It Not Be Stilled:' The Legacy of Debbie Friedman," in Michael A. Meyers, ed., *Between Jewish Tradition and Modernity: Rethinking an Old Opposition, Essays in Honor of David Ellenson* (Detroit: Wayne State University Press, 2014), 110-122

Ayelet Tsabari (she/her), "A Simple Girl." <https://www.jewishbookcouncil.org/pb-daily/a-simple-girl>

TFeb 10 Intro to Rituals, and Healing

Shulamit S. Magnus (she/her), "Ritual in the United States" <http://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/ritual-in-united-states>

Amy Eilberg (she/her), "El Na Refa Na La: Please, God, Heal My Daughter!," from Sue Levi Elwell and Nancy Fuchs Kreimer, *Chapters of the Heart: Jewish Women Sharing the Torah of Our Lives*

R Feb 12 Mikveh (Ritual Bath)

Beth Wenger (she/her), "Mikveh " *Shalvi/Hyman Encyclopedia of Jewish Women*. 23 June 2021. Jewish Women's Archive. <https://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/mikveh>

S.J. Crasnow (they/them), "On Transition: normative Judaism and trans innovation." *Journal of Contemporary Religion* 32:3, 403-415

TFeb 17 Bat Mitzvah

Paula Hyman (she/her) and Carole B. Balin (she/her), "[Bat Mitzvah: American Jewish Women](#)." The Jewish Women's Archive.

Emily Burack, "Tiffany Haddish Loves Being Jewish. We Talked to Her About It." <https://www.heyalma.com/tiffany-haddish-loves-being-jewish-we-talked-to-her-about-it/>

R Feb 19 Women and Everyday Objects

Laura Arnold Leibman (she/her), *The Art of the Jewish Family: A History of Women in Early New York in Five Objects* (New York: Bard Graduate Center, 2020), Chapter 4: "Commonplace Things"

Laura Leibman, "Sarah Rodrigues Brandon," <https://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/rodrigues-brandon-sarah>

Reading Schedule Continued

T Feb 24 Women and Art in Israel/Palestine

Olga Gershenson, "Zoya Cherkassky,"

<https://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/cherkassky-zoya>

Tal Dekel, "Vered Nissim,"

<https://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/nissim-vered>

(More may be added)

R Feb 26 NO IN PERSON CLASS

T March 3 TBD/Research Lessons

In class time for research and writing

R March 5

In class time for research and writing

Week of March 9: SPRING BREAK-NO CLASS

T March 17 Fat Torah

JWA, Can We Talk Podcast, "Fat Torah"

<https://jwa.org/podcasts/canwetalk/episode-86-fat-torah-minna-bromberg>

Minna Bronberg (she/her), *Fat Torah*, excerpts

R March 19 Queer Torah

Gregg Drinkwater (he/him), Joshua Lesser (he/him) and David Shneer (he/him), *Torah Queeries*, excerpts

Steven Greenberg (he/him), *Wrestling with God and Men* (Madison, WI, University of Wisconsin Press, 2004), excerpt

T March 24 Trans Torah

Joy Ladin (she/her), *The Soul of a Stranger: Reading God and Torah from a Transgender Perspective* (Brandeis University Press, 2018), excerpts

Noach Dzmura (he/him), *Balancing on the Mebitza*, excerpts



Reading schedule: continued

M March 31: Miriam, Objects, and Passover

Vanessa Ochs (she/her), "Miriam's Object Lesson," from Riv-Ellen Prell, editor, *Women Remaking American Judaism* (Wayne State University Press, 2007)

R APR 2: NO CLASS: PASSOVER DAY I

T APR 7 Jewish Children's Literature

Sydney Taylor (she/her), *All-of-a-Kind Family* series, selections

Rachel Gross (she/her), *Beyond the Synagogue: Jewish Nostalgia as Religious Practice* (NYU Press, 2021), excerpt

Idit Klein (she/her). "Lesléa Newman." *Shalvi/Hyman Encyclopedia of Jewish Women*. 25 April 2022. Jewish Women's Archive. <https://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/newman-leslea>



R APR 9: Jewish Food, Gender, and Identity

Beth DiNatale Johnson, "Lizzie Black Kander."

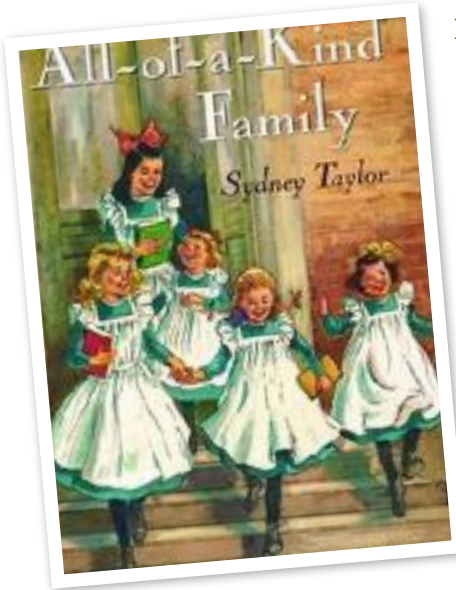
<https://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/kander-lizzie-black>

Beejhy Barony, *Gursha*, excerpts

T APR 14 Jewish Women and Comedy

Podcast: JWA, "Can We Talk? How Jewish Women Shaped SNL," with Lorraine Newman and Professor Jenny Caplan

<https://jwa.org/podcasts/canwetalk/episode-136-how-jewish-women-shaped-snl>



Jennifer Caplan, "Jewish Women and Comedy."

<https://jwa.org/encyclopedia/article/jewish-women-and-comedy>

Reading schedule: continued

RAPR 16: Environment and Ecofeminism

Sharon Wachsler (she/her), “Composting Judaism,” from *Yentl’s Revenge*

[“Jewish Women in Environmental Activism.”](#) Jewish Women’s Archive

TAPR 21: Art, Craft and Judaism

JWA Podcast, “Siona Benjamin’s Transcultural Art”

<https://jwa.org/podcasts/canwetalk/episode-52-siona-benamins-transcultural-art>

Jodi Eichler-Levine (she/her), *Painted Pomegranates and Needlepoint Rabbis: How Jews Craft Resilience and Create Community* (Chapel Hill: UNC Press, 2020), excerpts

If you are still reading this syllabus, email a picture of a cute animal or a humorous meme to me at joe315@lehigh.edu to receive 1 pt of extra credit on one of your papers.

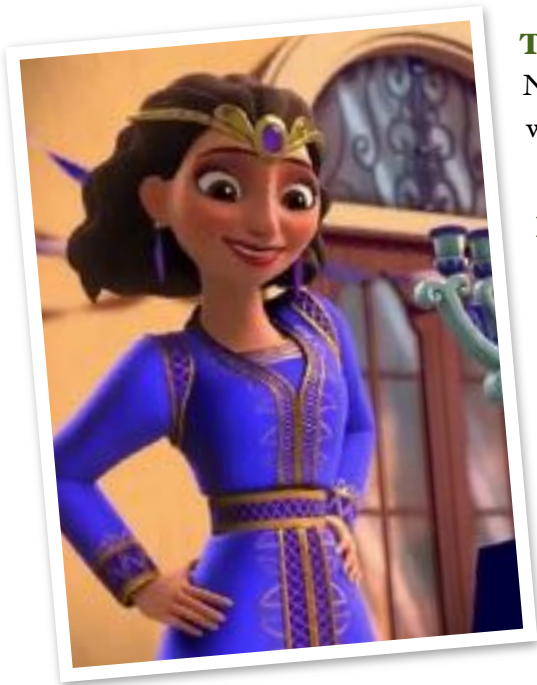


RAPR 23 : Jews, Gender, and Disney

Sarah Aroeste, [“Disney’s ‘Elena of Avalor’ Hanukkah Episode is a Win for Representation.”](#)

Lior Zaltzman, “The Amazing Jewish Lyricist Behind Your Favorite Disney Songs.”

https://www.kveller.com/the-amazing-jewish-lyricist-behind-your-favorite-disney-songs/?utm_source=mjl_maropost



TAPR 28 TBD or in-class sharing/writing

No reading—just some time to reflect and do some in class sharing and writing.

RAPR 30 LAST CLASS

No reading—just some time to reflect and do some in class sharing and writing.